Andropov. But hard as it was to swallow, the First Secretary acquiesced to Soviet demands and cancelled the trip.

Watching from afar, John Hughes, a spokesman from the US State Department, added to East German discomfort. ‘I think you have to look at the motivation of Mr Honecker and look at whatever pressures there may have been on him,’ he said. ‘Moscow clearly has not had a vested interest in this meeting going ahead.’4

Interestingly, remarking on the saga in his secret ‘Annual Report on the GDR to London’, the British Ambassador in East Berlin, Timothy Everard, observed that Honecker did ‘not look much chastened’, but ‘more like a man biding his time’, confident that mutual interests would eventually reassert the importance of inner German relations.5 ‘Meanwhile,’ the report added, ‘his standing up to the Russians, even if temporarily faced down, has been good for his own public image’. Everard remarked that while Honecker was ‘not exactly popular’, he was respected by broad sections of the population ‘both for his inner-German policies and for his evident concern for their material progress’.6

Meanwhile, the ailing Chernenko – literally on his last legs and only kept alive by doctors – struggled to keep up with other troubles, including the international backlash when Soviet forces shot down a South Korean airliner that accidentally strayed into Russian air space, with the loss of 269 lives. Then, in the sabre-rattling spirit of 1983, Ronald Reagan was re-elected US President in November, signalling gloomy implications for already strained relations. This was made worse by Reagan’s remark that the Soviet Union was an ‘evil empire … the focus of evil in the modern world’.7

Meanwhile, another crisis burst upon Honecker when 150 GDR citizens, desperate to gain passage to the West, began squatting at the FRG embassy in Prague, some even climbed over the gates seeking refuge. At the same time, others sought sanctuary in Western embassies in Warsaw, Budapest and Bucharest. This embarrassing trend even saw the niece of Willi Stoph enter the Prague embassy, she was permitted to emigrate to West Germany soon after. The squatting drama even played-out a few blocks from the SED headquarters when fifty-four East Germans took refuge in the FRG mission